

COVID is rising. Will it be cruel summer?

Following Northern California, Southland sees uptick. Next two weeks could be key.

By RONG-GONG LIN II

COVID-19 is once again on the rise in California. It remains to be seen whether this latest uptick foreshadows the sort of misery seen last year — when the state was walloped by its worst summertime surge since 2022 — or proves fleeting. But officials and experts say it's nevertheless a reminder of the seasonal potency of the still-circulating virus.

"We definitely are seeing an uptick in the summer," Dr. Erica Pan, director of the California Department of Public Health and the state health officer, said during a recent webinar.

As has often been the case with COVID, the latest increase in infections is not playing out uniformly across the state. The uptick was first registered in Northern California and started being seen in Southern California only more recently.

Dr. Elizabeth Hudson, regional physician chief of infectious diseases for Kaiser Permanente Southern California, said she expects an uptick in cases in the Southland over the next two to three weeks, based on the level of coronavirus being detected in wastewater.

"My colleagues at Northern California Kaiser Permanente have already noticed this trend, so I suspect it will be coming to Los Angeles soon," Hudson said.

However, COVID activity remains well below the level seen last summer at this point — and it's too soon to say how bad this season will be. Although last summer saw a particularly potent spike in infections, this past winter was the mildest of the COVID era.

"We'll know over the next couple of weeks which direction things are going," Hudson said.

It remains possible that COVID could end up being as active as last year, if not worse, according to Dr. Peter Chin-Hong, an infectious-disease expert at UC San Francisco.

"It's been a longer time since a lot of people got infected," Chin-Hong said, noting California's last busy COVID season was about a year ago, and immunity has waned since then. "And just like last year, there are new

[See COVID-19, A6]



MIGRANTS wait for the Border Patrol in Jacumba Hot Springs, Calif., in May 2024 after crossing the border.

‘People are dying in line’: A legal path to U.S. is elusive

Amid raids, politicians see a window for immigration reform

By RACHEL URANGA

John Manley is sick of people telling immigrants to “stand in line” and “do it the right way.”

An immigration attorney for almost three decades in Los Angeles, he said what most don't understand is that trying to legally come into the United States is nearly impossible for people from certain nations such as Mexico.

“People are dying in line,” he said. In some cases, “it's

literally a 150-year wait.”

Manley said one of his clients, a U.S. citizen originally from Mexico who petitioned his two brothers to become legal residents, waited more than 15 years and wound up burying them instead of giving them the good news.

“They're trying their best. They're waiting in line,” he said. “But when you have a system that was essentially designed to fail from the beginning, it's difficult to have faith in that system.”

Immigration laws have

not seen a wholesale reform in nearly 40 years, but as the Trump administration cracks down on unauthorized migrants, politicians are seeing a window of opportunity. Economists, immigration attorneys and scholars say that without another relief valve, it is not just the immigrants who will suffer but people in a wide swath of the economy.

Sen. Alex Padilla (D-Calif.) on Monday plans to introduce legislation that could provide a path to citizenship to 11 million immi-

grants who have lived in the U.S. for at least seven years. With a Republican-led House and Senate, the legislation, which died last year, is unlikely to pass, but Padilla said he wanted to reintroduce the bill because he sensed a “mood shift” in Congress and across the country.

He's not the only one. This month in the House, Reps. Maria Elvira Salazar (R-Fla.) and Veronica Escobar (D-Texas) dusted off their legislation, the Dig-

[See Immigration, A5]

Revival for defunct General Hospital

The assignment was to reimagine the mothballed and dilapidated General Hospital building that towers over the Eastside as the centerpiece of a vibrant new health-oriented community.

Eighteen months after securing an exclusive negotiating agreement, the team selected for the job has completed a conceptual plan and is set to take the first concrete steps in a redevelopment program that could take a decade.

With an authorization of \$120 million for remediation, Centennial Partners has begun design work on upgrades to prepare the 93-year-old building for its new life as a mixed-use center with medical offices, commercial space and up to 824 residential units.

In its concept plan, Centennial Partners outlined an

93-year-old facility is reimaged as mixed-use health-oriented site

By DOUG SMITH



A VISITOR takes in the Art Deco vestibule. The hospital is shown in the title scene of the soap opera.

overarching vision for its proposal to remake the 19-story hospital and its adjoining 41.9-acre campus into a neighborhood of affordable, workforce and market-rate housing, retail stores, health services, open space and connections to public transit.

Calling the project “a national model for equitable urban development,” it proposed a phased development with wide latitude in scale, providing scenarios ranging from as few as 1,480 mixed-income residential units to as many as 4,954, and from 2.1 million to 4.6 million square feet of commercial space.

The preliminary plan, issued in February, is the basis for a detailed master plan and environmental report Centennial Partners is ex-

[See Hospital, A6]

New wrinkle to L.A.'s parking woes: payment

By DEBORAH NETBURN

Matt Glaeser had just dropped his kids off at their grandparents' house for the day when he pulled into a parking spot near Sam's Bagels on Larchmont Boulevard on his way to work. He tried to feed the meter from a roll of quarters he keeps in his car, but the coin slot was jammed. He reached for his credit card but then noticed the screen said “Pay by app” and showed a QR code.

He tried to scan the QR code with his phone, but the screen was so scratched with graffiti it didn't work. So he sent a text to the number on the “Pay to Park” sticker below the coin slot. After waiting for a minute and wondering if the text went through, he received a text back with a link to a website. He opened the site on his phone and typed in his credit card number and ad-

dress. But before he completed the payment, the site alerted him that he would have to pay an additional processing fee just to park for 15 minutes.

“It was only 35 cents, but I was like, ‘Forget this, I'll find a stale bagel in the office,’” Glaeser said.

Finding parking in the L.A. area has long been a struggle, but these days, paying for parking can be just as odious. Depending on whether you're parking in L.A., Santa Monica, Beverly Hills or Pasadena, a meter might ask you to pay with quarters, a credit card, an app or some combination of all three. In public lots, you might need to memorize a zone, space number or license plate and often don't know which one until you get to the pay station. It's enough to make a law-abiding citizen give up, cross her fingers and hope a parking

[See Parking, A12]



JUAN JOSÉ ESTRADA SERAFÍN For The Times

FARMWORKER LAID TO REST

Mourners in Mexico's Michoacán state bid farewell to Jaime Alanis García, who was fatally injured during an immigration raid in Camarillo. **NATION, A5**

American killed during Syria visit

There to help his sick father, he was executed in sectarian violence. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

Telling Katrina survivors' stories

TV critic Robert Lloyd finds docuseries on 2005 disaster compelling. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 81/61. **B6**

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U.S. AND EU OK 15% TARIFFS FOR MOST EXPORTS

Trump's deal with Europe averts trade war that could have global repercussions.

By WILL WEISSERT

EDINBURGH, Scotland — The United States and the European Union agreed Sunday to a trade framework setting a 15% tariff on most goods, staying off — at least for now — far higher import taxes on both sides that might have sent shock waves through economies around the globe.

The sweeping announcement came after President Trump and European Commission chief Ursula von der Leyen met briefly at Trump's Turnberry golf course in Scotland. Their private meeting culminated months of bargaining, with the White House deadline Friday nearing for imposing punishing tariffs on the EU's 27 member countries.

“It was a very interesting negotiation. I think it's going to be great for both parties,” Trump said. The agreement, he said, was “a good deal for everybody” and “a giant deal with lots of countries.”

Von der Leyen said the agreement “will bring stability, it will bring predictability that's very important for our businesses on both sides of the Atlantic.”

As with other recent tariff agreements that Trump announced with countries including Japan and the United Kingdom, some major details remain pending.

Trump said the EU had agreed to buy about \$750 billion worth of U.S. energy and invest \$600 billion more than it already is in the United

[See Tariffs, A7]

EPA cuts research, so state steps up

Officials at Office of Environmental Health Hazard Assessment look to bridge the gap.

By HAYLEY SMITH

In the wake of the Trump administration's decision to dismantle the research arm of the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency, a robust if little-known California agency called the Office of Environmental Health Hazard Assessment is poised to take on an even bigger role to bridge the gap.

The EPA this month announced that it was eliminating nearly 4,000 employees as part of a cost-saving “reduction in force,” the majority of which are staffers from its Office of Research and Development — whose research into environmental risks and hazards underpins nearly all EPA rules and regulations. The reduction will save the agency \$748.8 million, officials said.

“Under President Trump's leadership, EPA has taken a close look at our operations to ensure the agency is better equipped than ever to deliver on our core mission of protecting human health and the environment while Powering the Great American Comeback,” read a statement from EPA administrator Lee Zeldin. “This reduction in force will ensure we can bet-

[See Agency, A7]